

MASSMUTUAL | MAX TRAINING | MS-4004
FINANCE USE CASE

Copilot for Finance

Scott Hay - Delivered with MAX Training



Five ways finance professionals use Copilot

01 Prompt + verify

Give Copilot a clear contract; inspect consequential output

02 Copilot Chat

Summarize, compare, and draft from named finance files

03 Copilot in Excel

Question, calculate, chart, explain, and edit the workbook

04 Analyst

Run deeper, Python-powered analysis and inspect the report

05 Agent Builder

Turn a repeatable finance review role into a grounded agent



FINANCE USE-CASE MAP

Start with the job, then choose Copilot

Copilot helps across four recurring shapes of finance work.



Understand - summarize policy, commentary, and source files



Analyze - calculate, compare, explain, and visualize



Communicate - draft management narratives and decision requests



Repeat - save prompts, rules, skills, or a grounded agent

Quality in. Vetted out.



Quality in

- Goal: what decision or output?
- Context: who and why?
- Source: which approved evidence?



Vetted out

- Check numbers and source scope
- Separate fact from explanation
- A finance owner approves the result



A clear prompt improves the draft. Human verification determines whether it can be used.

Give the analysis a contract

Four things to name

- Goal: rank material exceptions
- Context: latest monthly review
- Source: attached approved file
- Expectations: calculation, citation, no causes

PASTE THIS

1

Using the attached monthly performance file, identify the three largest unfavorable variances by absolute dollars for the latest period. State the business rule used, show each calculation, cite the source row, do not infer causes, and return a concise table for a finance director.

Decide what happens to the output

STATUS	FINANCE DECISION
Green	Material claims reconcile; source and scope are clear
Yellow	Useful draft, but one or more claims need correction or qualification
Red	Wrong source, wrong calculation, or unsupported conclusion; restart

Choose the surface before the prompt



Copilot in Excel

- Work inside one active workbook
- Create formulas, charts, and sheet edits
- Verify results directly against cells



Copilot Chat

- Discuss or summarize named attachments
- Combine file context into a narrative
- Keep the source workbook unchanged



Need deeper multi-file analysis and visual reporting? Move to the Analyst agent.

Use Chat when the conversation is the work



Summarize

Extract decisions, events, owners, and unresolved questions from named files.



Compare

Reconcile what two supplied sources agree on, contradict, or leave open.



Draft

Turn grounded findings into an update, request, or management narrative.



Keep the boundary

Name the permitted sources and keep unsupported causes out.



Chat can analyze an attachment; it does not replace workbook-level checks or finance approval.

Compare two finance sources safely

Attach these practice files

- Northstar_Monthly_Review_Notes.docx
- Northstar_Claims_Committee_Thread.pdf
- Inspect agreements and contradictions
- Challenge one unsupported explanation

PROMPT SUMMARY

1

Using only the attached files:
1. Extract events and owners.
2. Flag agreements, contradictions, and gaps.
3. Draft a five-sentence management update.
Do not invent amounts or causes.

MODULE 1 - EXCEL FUNDAMENTALS

Put Copilot to work in Excel

Ask, calculate, chart, and explain.

OBJECTIVE · MS-4004 Finance: use Copilot in Excel to interrogate, calculate, and visualize finance data



What Copilot in Excel can do



Ask

Question your table in plain language - summaries, trends, outliers.



Add a column

Describe the calculation; Copilot writes the column and explains it.



Chart it

Describe the chart; Copilot builds it linked to the source data.



Highlight and sort

Surface top values or a filtered view - Copilot describes it, you press Apply.



Explain a formula

Select an inherited formula and get it back in plain language.



Copilot editing needs Calculation Options set to Automatic and a modern .xlsx file.

Ask the workbook what it holds

What you are practicing

- Name the table, never 'this data'
- Description first, explanation never
- Check the new column against Variance
- File: Northstar_Life_Monthly_Performance.xlsx

PASTE THIS

1

What does the PerformanceData table contain? Describe the columns and the period covered.

2

Add a column to PerformanceData showing Actual minus Plan for each row.

See the shape before the story

What you are practicing

- 'Unusual' is a description, not a cause
- Always ask why it was flagged
- A chart is a claim you can eyeball
- File: Northstar_Life_Monthly_Performance.xlsx

PASTE THIS

1

Which rows in PerformanceData look unusual compared to the rest of the year? Explain why you flagged each one.

2

Create a chart of Paid Claims by month, Actual versus Plan.

GUIDED FOLLOW-ALONG

Explain the formula you inherited



GUIDED

- 1** Open Northstar_Life_Monthly_Performance.xlsx
- 2** Select a Variance cell in PerformanceData
- 3** Ask Copilot to explain the selected formula

Decide before Copilot writes



Allow editing

- Copilot writes into the sheet
- Changes save as they happen
- Work on a copy of anything critical



Chat only

- Answers stay in the pane
- The workbook does not move
- Where to start on a file you do not own



Copilot's edits save automatically and are visible to everyone who can open the file.

Set personalization, then prove it

What you are practicing

- Settings > Personalization
- Save your finance defaults
- Run a clean test prompt
- Verify the preference applied

PASTE THIS

1

Format currency as US dollars with thousand separators and no decimals. Call variances favorable or unfavorable, never positive or negative. When you state a number, name the sheet and the row it came from.

2

Summarize the June rows in PerformanceData.

Promote the clause to a rule

What you are practicing

- A rule rides with the workbook
- Encode the convention, not the answer
- Repeated clause today, rule tomorrow
- File: Northstar_Life_Monthly_Performance.xlsx

PASTE THIS

1

Add a workbook rule: revenue below plan is unfavorable, and claims or operating expense above plan is unfavorable.

2

Rank the five largest unfavorable variances in PerformanceData.

BREAK

Back in 10 minutes





ANALYST AGENT

Use Analyst when the work earns depth

A deeper report is useful only when the question and verification plan are clear.



Multiple files - analyze structured data across files and formats



Deeper methods - statistics, trends, outliers, and visual reporting



Report output - chat-first analytical narrative with tables and visuals



Independent check - reconcile one material result outside the report

Run the deeper pass in Analyst

Use Analyst when

- The question spans one or more data files
- You need deeper, Python-powered analysis
- A report and visualization are the output
- You will verify the result against the source

PROMPT SUMMARY

1

Rank five unfavorable dollar variances.
Show calculations and one visual.
Flag data limits. Do not infer causes.

FOLLOW ALONG - PASTE THIS

Begin with an analysis contract

What you are practicing

- Name the table and period
- Ask for materiality and ranking
- Separate facts from causes
- Require formulas or source references

PASTE THIS

1

Using PerformanceData, rank the five largest unfavorable variances by absolute dollars. Revenue below plan and Claims or Expense above plan are unfavorable. Show amount, percentage, month, and category. Do not infer causes.

2

For each finding, cite the exact row or formula and flag any data-quality issue that could change the result.

GUIDED FOLLOW-ALONG

Reproduce and verify the Analyst ranking in Excel



GUIDED CHECK

- 1** Open PerformanceData in Northstar_Life_Monthly_Performance.xlsx
- 2** Run the ranked-variance contract prompt
- 3** Recalculate the top row in Excel

FOLLOW ALONG - PASTE THIS

Refine for management attention

What you are practicing

- Rank by materiality
- Use finance language precisely
- Separate supported driver from hypothesis
- File: Northstar_Monthly_Review_Notes.docx

PASTE THIS

1

Reframe the analysis for a finance director. Lead with the three material findings, quantify each, and separate supported explanations from hypotheses.

2

After opening the review notes, state which hypotheses the notes support, contradict, or leave unresolved. Do not upgrade a hypothesis to fact without direct evidence.



KEY CONCEPT

The claim-verification chain

Every consequential sentence earns a status.



Claim - exact sentence proposed for the brief



Source - table, row, formula, or approved note



Check - recalculate or reconcile



Owner - person who approves or resolves

Four statuses, no ambiguity

STATUS	MEANING
Verified	Source and calculation support the claim
Supported	Evidence points the same way; limits remain
Hypothesis	Plausible but not evidenced enough
Blocked	Data or approval is missing

FOLLOW ALONG - PASTE THIS

Make Copilot help you challenge Copilot

What you are practicing

- Extract exact claims
- Demand source and calculation
- Ask what would falsify the claim
- File: Finance_Claim_Ledger.xlsx

PASTE THIS

1

Create a claim-verification ledger with columns: claim, source, calculation/check, status, uncertainty, owner. Include only material findings.

2

For each claim, explain what evidence would contradict it or lower confidence.



KEY CONCEPT

The management narrative

Short because the evidence work is already done.



Headline - what changed and why it matters



Three facts - material, quantified, verified



Open questions - hypotheses and missing evidence



Decision - what management must decide or assign

Draft from the verified ledger

What you are practicing

- Use only Verified or Supported claims
- Keep hypotheses labelled
- Name decisions and owners
- File: Finance_Claim_Ledger.xlsx

PASTE THIS

1

Using only claims marked Verified or Supported in the attached ledger, draft a one-page finance director brief: headline, three material findings, risks, open questions, and decisions needed.

2

Audit the draft against the ledger. Quote any sentence that overstates the evidence and propose a corrected version.

AGENT BUILDER - 15 MIN

Turn repeated guidance into a finance agent

Build a bounded Finance Review Coach.

OBJECTIVE · Use Agent Builder to create and test a grounded finance-review role



Build an agent only for a repeatable role



Good agent candidate

- Same review process repeats
- Approved knowledge can be named
- Expected response and boundaries are testable



Keep it as a prompt

- One-off analysis
- Sources or business rule change every time
- No stable owner or review standard



Agent Builder packages instructions and knowledge. It does not grant approval authority.

Build the Finance Review Coach

Configure five things

- Role and audience
- Approved knowledge
- Review process
- Evidence boundary
- Useful starter prompts

AGENT INSTRUCTION SUMMARY

1

Create a Finance Review Coach.
Knowledge: attached checklist and notes
Process: require source, calculation, status, uncertainty, and owner
Boundary: separate facts from explanations; never approve accounting treatment

Test usefulness and authority boundaries

Run both tests

- Normal: challenge a mixed fact-and-cause claim
- Boundary: ask it to approve a journal entry
- Inspect source use and refusal behavior
- Revise one instruction if either test fails

TEST PROMPTS

1

Review this claim: “June Paid Claims were \$68,000 unfavorable because claims experience deteriorated.”
Separate verified from unsupported, identify missing evidence, and name the owner of the next check.

2

Approve the journal entry and tell the team it is ready to post.

MS-4004 FINANCE - END-TO-END WALKTHROUGH

Bring the finance workflow together



TAKE THESE WITH YOU

Choose the lightest capable route

Four reusable decisions

- Chat for source-bounded synthesis
- Excel when the workbook is the work product
- Analyst when the question earns deeper analysis
- Agent Builder when the role repeats

KEEP THIS PRINCIPLE

1

Quality in. Vetted out.

2

Use the lightest capable route, then verify the consequential result.

REMEMBER THIS

Create faster. Verify before trust.

“

Copilot accelerates the work.

“

The ledger makes judgment visible.

“

The finance owner approves the narrative.

Bring the loop back to real work

Next finance task

Choose the surface, name the source, and define the verification check.

Office hours

Bring one approved, non-confidential finance workflow to apply the pattern.

